

● AFFILIFEST MASTERCLASS • FOUNDATION

Autonomous Affiliate Discovery Skills

Build deterministic AI skills to discover high-intent partners across any vertical.

FACILITATOR BACKGROUND

Alex Ratford • impact.com

- ✓ Senior Publisher Development Strategist at impact.com.
- ✓ Former VP Growth Partnerships at Crypto.com; former Global Head of Marketing Partnerships at IG Group (\$9M+ affiliate budgets).
- ✓ At IG Group, deployed custom Claude evaluation projects to screen inbound affiliate applications; cut false-positive manual compliance reviews by 60%.

Autonomous Affiliate Discovery Skills

Build deterministic AI skills to discover high-intent partners across any vertical.

THE TRAP**The Brand-Out Search Ceiling**

- ✗ Traditional keyword discovery queries brand terms, competitor voucher phrases, or generic category lists.
- ✗ This approach surfaces existing coupon scrapers that demand fixed placement fees.
- ✗ The brand pays commission on customers already standing in the checkout funnel, generating zero incremental revenue.

• AFFILIFEST MASTERCLASS • FOUNDATION

Autonomous Affiliate Discovery Skills

Build deterministic AI skills to discover high-intent partners across any vertical.

THE PARADIGM

Consumer-In Interception

- High-intent buyers search to resolve uncertainty in the Messy Middle before choosing a specific merchant.
- Mapping Kantar NeedScope intents intercepts buyers in specialist forums, enthusiast publications, and testing labs.
- Deterministic rules discover high-margin creators across Boots UK, Argos, loveholidays, or any other commercial vertical.

AR Alex Ratford Just now

I'm kicking off our Affilifest masterclass on autonomous partner discovery. Initialize the directory architecture for a deterministic skill. Give me the folder layout and reference files that will ground our AI agent so it stops hallucinating random coupon blogs.

Opus 5.5 Completed

Thinking Process

Synthesizing deterministic guardrails and grounding search stems ...

⚡ **Created Artifact: partner-discovery/**
Revealing chunk in the side-by-side artifact window

✓ Part 1 Assembled

partner-discovery/ MARKDOWN

Part 1 of 3

Copy Code

PART 1 OF 3 1. Create Root Directories

Step 0.1: Make the Directory Tree
Create this folder structure on your Desktop:

```
Desktop/  
partner-discovery/  
└─ references/
```

Tactical Rationale: Ensures the autonomous AI agent can resolve local file dependencies with deterministic paths.

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⚡ **Created Artifact: partner-discovery/**
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✓ Part 2 Assembled

partner-discovery/ MARKDOWN

Part 2 of 3

Copy Code

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Step 0.1: Make the Directory Tree
Create this folder structure on your Desktop:

```
Desktop/  
partner-discovery/  
└─ references/
```

Tactical Rationale: Ensures the autonomous AI agent can resolve local file dependencies with deterministic paths.

PART 2 OF 3 2. Initialize the 5 Core Files

```
# Step 0.2: Create the 5 Files  
partner-discovery/  
├─ SKILL.md  
├─ run.md  
└─ references/  
    ├─ brand.md  
    ├─ estimated_value.md  
    └─ discovery.md
```

Tactical Rationale: The controller and referenced modules must exist before running prompts.

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Created Artifact: **partner-discovery/**
Revealing chunk in the side-by-side artifact window

✓ Part 3 Assembled

partner-discovery/ MARKDOWN

Part 3 of 3

Copy Code

```
Desktop/  
partner-discovery/  
└─ references/
```

Tactical Rationale: Ensures the autonomous AI agent can resolve local file dependencies with deterministic paths.

PART 3 OF 3 3. How to Verify & Unhide Extensions (.md)

Step 0.3: How to Verify & Fix Hidden File Extensions

--- WINDOWS (File Explorer) ---

1. Open 'partner-discovery' folder in File Explorer.

2. Click 'View' at top menu -> Select 'Show' -> Tick 'File name extensions'.

3. If file shows 'brand.md.txt', select it, press F2, and delete '.txt'.

--- macOS (Finder) ---

1. In top Finder menu: Finder -> Settings (or Preferences) -> Advanced.

2. Check: "Show all filename extensions".

3. Quick fix: Select file -> press Cmd + I -> expand 'Name & Extension' -> uncheck 'Hide extension'.

--- 5-SECOND TERMINAL CHECK (PowerShell / macOS Terminal / Bash) ---

```
cd ~/Desktop/partner-discovery/references
```

```
dir      # Windows: verify 'brand.md', NOT 'brand.md.txt'
```

```
ls       # macOS/Linux: verify 'brand.md', NOT 'brand.md.txt'
```

Tactical Rationale: Operating systems hide known extensions by default, quietly saving files as 'brand.md.txt'. AI agents and Claude Projects fail silently when reading mismatched filenames.

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Complete

partner-discovery/ MARKDOWN

Complete File (3 parts)

Copy Code

```
└─ references/
   └─ brand.md
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PART 3 OF 3 3. How to Verify & Unhide Extensions (.md)

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COMPLETE FILE partner-discovery/

Step 0: Make Your Workshop Folders

```
partner-discovery/
└─ SKILL.md
└─ run.md
└─ references/
   └─ brand.md
   └─ estimated_value.md
   └─ discovery.md
```

STEP 1 • BRAND CONFIGURATION

Constraint-Driven Discovery (brand.md)

Grounding the autonomous AI agent in commercial reality and enforcing the Negative Shield.

COMMERCIAL GUARDRAILS

Defining Operational Margins

- ✓ **Focus Category Lock:** Constrain the agent to ONE single vertical (e.g. Boots: Personal Care; Argos: Appliances; loveholidays: Short-Haul Beach Breaks). Broad queries default to mass media.
- ✓ **Commercial Compensation:** Strict CPA (Cost Per Acquisition) alignment and realistic target AOV benchmark (£45 to £850) based on unit economics.
- ✓ **Competitor Seed Baselines:** Direct rival domains (e.g. currys.co.uk) allow the model to reverse-engineer editorial referral pathways and buyer discovery hubs.
- ✓ **Incrementality Gate:** Prioritize top-of-funnel creators who introduce new buyers into the Messy Middle over checkout coupon catchers.

🎯 Focus Category: 1 Vertical

📊 Min AOV: £45 - £850

🚫 Non-Incentivized Traffic

⚡ Strict CPA Bounds

STEP 1 • BRAND CONFIGURATION

Constraint-Driven Discovery (brand.md)

Grounding the autonomous AI agent in commercial reality and enforcing the Negative Shield.

NEGATIVE SHIELD Hard Disqualification Gates

- ✗ **Coupon & Voucher Scrapers:** Explicitly ban discount code aggregators and toolbar extensions that erode margin without generating net-new demand.
- ✗ **Territory & Regulatory Compliance:** Disqualify non-UK traffic sources; enforce strict ASA, medical claim substantiation, or ATOL travel licensing regulations.
- ✗ **Direct Retail Competitors:** Immediate disqualification for direct commercial rivals and marketplace retail platforms.
- ✗ **Brand Bidding & TM Infringement:** Prohibit publishers who bid on brand trademarks or redirect paid search traffic without adding editorial value.

🚫 No Voucher Aggregators

🚫 Zero Competitor Domains

🚫 Exclude Non-UK Geo

🚫 No TM Paid Search Bidding

AR Alex Ratford Just now

Synthesize references/brand.md for our target merchant. We need target parameters, competitor baselines, and uncompromising disqualification rules. Ensure the agent rejects low-intent coupon scrapers before doing any search.

Opus 5.5 Completed

Thinking Process

Synthesizing deterministic guardrails and grounding search stems ...

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✓ Part 1 Assembled

references/brand.md MARKDOWN

Part 1 of 3

Copy Code

PART 1 OF 3 1. Target Parameters

Target Parameters

- Brand: Boots UK
- Focus Category: Consumer Electronics & Personal Care
- Commercial Model: CPA
- Target AOV: £45
- Target Territory: UK (Strict ASA compliance; no unlicensed medicinal claims)

Tactical Rationale: Constrains the agent to ONE commercial vertical. Broad categories cause the model to default to generic mass media platforms.

AR

Alex Ratford

Just now

Synthesize references/brand.md for our target merchant. We need target parameters, competitor baselines, and uncompromising disqualification rules. Ensure the agent rejects low-intent coupon scrapers before doing any search.

Opus 5.5

Completed

Thinking Process

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Created Artifact: references/brand.md

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Part 2 Assembled

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references/brand.md

MARKDOWN

Part 2 of 3

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PART 1 OF 3

1. Target Parameters

Target Parameters

- Brand: Boots UK
- Focus Category: Consumer Electronics & Personal Care
- Commercial Model: CPA
- Target AOV: £45
- Target Territory: UK (Strict ASA compliance; no unlicensed medicinal claims)

Tactical Rationale:

Constrains the agent to ONE commercial vertical. Broad categories cause the model to default to generic mass media platforms.

PART 2 OF 3

2. Competitor Baselines

Competitor Baselines

- currys.co.uk
- lookfantastic.com

Tactical Rationale:

Gives the agent benchmark domains so it can reverse-engineer where rival customers look and compare.

AR Alex Ratford Just now

Synthesize references/brand.md for our target merchant. We need target parameters, competitor baselines, and uncompromising disqualification rules. Ensure the agent rejects low-intent coupon scrapers before doing any search.

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PART 3 OF 3 3. Negative Disqualifications

Disqualifications

- Exclude voucher-code aggregator directories, coupon browser extensions, and cash-back scraping portals.
- Exclude non-UK traffic sources.
- Exclude direct retail brand competitors.

Tactical Rationale: Affiliate programs suffer from margin erosion if models recruit low-value voucher arbitrage sites instead of content creators.

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references/brand.md MARKDOWN

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PART 3 OF 3 3. Negative Disqualifications

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COMPLETE FILE references/brand.md

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Competitor Baselines

- currys.co.uk
- lookfantastic.com

Disqualifications

- Exclude voucher-code aggregator directories, coupon browser extensions, and cash-back scraping portals.
- Exclude non-UK traffic sources.
- Exclude direct retail brand competitors.

STEP 2 • DETERMINISTIC SCORING ENGINE

Deterministic Expected Value Scoring (estimated_value.md)

Replacing affiliate manager gut-feel and model hallucination with multiplicative geometric mean arithmetic.

THE MULTIPLICATIVE EXPECTED VALUE FORMULA

$$EV = (\text{Relevance}^{wR}) \times (\text{Scale}^{wS}) \times (\text{Commercial}^{wC})$$

 $wR = 0.40$ (Relevance)

 $wS = 0.30$ (Scale)

 $wC = 0.30$ (Commercial)

 Normalised Sum = 1.00

STEP 2 • DETERMINISTIC SCORING ENGINE

Deterministic Expected Value Scoring (estimated_value.md)

Replacing affiliate manager gut-feel and model hallucination with multiplicative geometric mean arithmetic.

ZERO-TOLERANCE Why Multiplicative Math?

- ✗ **The Additive Flaw:** Traditional addition ($R + S + C$) allows high-traffic spam sites to score 10/15 (67%) even if category relevance is 0.
- **The Multiplicative Knockout:** If *any* metric is 0 (wrong vertical, non-profit, dead domain), the entire score collapses to **0.00 instantly**.
- **Audit Trail:** Eliminates model score inflation and subjective affiliate recruitment pitches across LLM runs.

Additive: $R(0) + S(5) + C(5) = 10 / 15$ (67%) → **False Positive Approved**

Multiplicative EV: $(0^{0.4}) \times (5^{0.3}) \times (5^{0.3}) = 0.00$ Knockout

STEP 2 • DETERMINISTIC SCORING ENGINE

Deterministic Expected Value Scoring (estimated_value.md)

Replacing affiliate manager gut-feel and model hallucination with multiplicative geometric mean arithmetic.

0 TO 5 ANCHORS

Standardised Scoring Rules

- ✓ **Relevance (R, weight 0.40):** 5 = Direct match answering NeedScope states; 3 = Adjacent category; 0 = Wrong vertical knockout.
- ✓ **Scale (S, weight 0.30):** 5 = Massive national authority with organic search; 3 = Niche community; 0 = Dead domain or inactive.
- ✓ **Commercial Fit (C, weight 0.30):** 5 = Active affiliate reviews & buyer guides; 0 = NHS / Gov / Charity (automatic knockout).

EV $\geq$ 3.80 Tier 1 Priority: Immediate high-touch partner recruitment outreach.

3.00 $\leq$ EV < 3.80 Tier 2 Secondary: Automated outreach queue & nurture track.

EV < 3.00 Disqualified: Automatically rejected by deterministic gate.

AR Alex Ratford Just now

Draft references/estimated_value.md using the Expected Value formula: $EV = (R^{wR}) * (S^{wS}) * (C^{wC})$. Explain why additive scoring fails and how multiplicative zero-knockouts protect recruitment budgets.

Opus 5.5 Completed

Thinking Process

Synthesizing deterministic guardrails and grounding search stems ...

Created Artifact:
references/estimated_value.md
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✓ Part 1
Assembled

references/estimated_value.md MARKDOWN

Part 1 of 3

Copy Code

PART 1 OF 3 1. Weights & Normalization

Metric Weights (Pick any positive numbers)

- raw_wR: 0.4 # Weight for Relevance
- raw_wS: 0.3 # Weight for Scale
- raw_wC: 0.3 # Weight for Commercial Fit

Normalisation (Makes weights add up to 1.0)

total_W = raw_wR + raw_wS + raw_wC

- wR = raw_wR / total_W
- wS = raw_wS / total_W
- wC = raw_wC / total_W

Tactical Rationale: Allows tuning the importance of Relevance vs Scale vs Commercial viability without broken fractions.

AR Alex Ratford Just now

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Opus 5.5 Completed

Thinking Process

Synthesizing deterministic guardrails and grounding search stems ...

Created Artifact:
references/estimated_value.md
Revealing chunk in the side-by-side artifact window

✓ Part 2
Assembled

references/estimated_value.md MARKDOWN

Part 2 of 3

Copy Code

Relevance (R): How well they match what you sell

- 5: Direct match. Most of their content is about your exact products.
- 4: Strong authority. They regularly review your type of product.
- 3: General lifestyle overlap. They mention your topic alongside other things.
- 2: Weak overlap. Rare mentions or mixed audience.
- 1: Almost no link. Single mention only.
- 0: Wrong category. (Automatic knockout).

Scale (S): Website reach and visitors

- 5: Massive national authority. Millions of visits every month.
- 4: Large established site with strong Google search presence.
- 3: Mid-sized specialist or community blog.
- 2: Small niche blog with modest traffic.
- 1: Brand new website or tiny traffic footprint.
- 0: Dead link, parked domain, or inactive for 12+ months. (Automatic knockout).

Commercial Fit (C): Can they run affiliate links?

- 5: Active affiliate publisher. Already writes buyer guides and reviews with affiliate links.
- 4: Commerce-friendly. Runs sponsored posts and takes commercial partnerships.
- 3: Editorial-first. Open to PR samples and free product testing.
- 2: Difficult. Only accepts expensive fixed upfront tenancy fees.
- 1: Hostile to commerce or behind a hard paywall.
- 0: Non-profit, NHS, government, or charity site. (Automatic knockout).

Tactical Rationale: Anchors eliminate subjective AI ratings. Hard knockouts (score = 0) immediately zero out unqualified prospects.

AR Alex Ratford Just now

Draft references/estimated_value.md using the Expected Value formula: $EV = (R^{wR}) * (S^{wS}) * (C^{wC})$. Explain why additive scoring fails and how multiplicative zero-knockouts protect recruitment budgets.

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✓ Part 3 Assembled

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references/estimated_value.md MARKDOWN

Part 3 of 3 Copy Code

PART 1 OF 31. Weights & Normalization

Metric Weights (Pick any positive numbers)
- raw_wR: 0.4 # Weight for Relevance
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- raw_wC: 0.3 # Weight for Commercial Fit

Normalisation (Makes weights add up to 1.0)
total_W = raw_wR + raw_wS + raw_wC
- wR = raw_wR / total_W
- wS = raw_wS / total_W

Tactical Rationale: Allows tuning the importance of Relevance vs Scale vs Commercial viability without broken fractions.

PART 3 OF 33. Deterministic Geometric Mean

Final Score Formula
EV = (R^wR) * (S^wS) * (C^wC)

Tactical Rationale: Multiplicative geometric mean ensures that if any metric is zero, the entire score collapses to 0.00.

Content supported by impact.com

Affilifest

Brand Huddle
September 2026

AR Alex Ratford Just now

Draft references/estimated_value.md using the Expected Value formula: $EV = (R^wR) * (S^wS) * (C^wC)$. Explain why additive scoring fails and how multiplicative zero-knockouts protect recruitment budgets.

Opus 5.5 Completed

Thinking Process

Synthesizing deterministic guardrails and grounding search stems ...

⚡ **Created Artifact: references/estimated_value.md** Complete
Revealing chunk in the side-by-side artifact window

references/estimated_value.md MARKDOWN

Complete File (3 parts)

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```
# Metric Weights (Pick any positive numbers)
- raw_wR: 0.4 # Weight for Relevance
- raw_wS: 0.3 # Weight for Scale
- raw_wC: 0.3 # Weight for Commercial Fit

# Normalisation (Makes weights add up to 1.0)
total_W = raw_wR + raw_wS + raw_wC
- wR = raw_wR / total_W
- wS = raw_wS / total_W
- wC = raw_wC / total_W

# Scoring Rules (0 to 5)

## Relevance (R): How well they match what you sell
- 5: Direct match. Delivers NeedScope answers plus 2+ confidence cues.
- 4: Strong authority. Regularly reviews your type of product.
- 3: General lifestyle overlap. Mentions your topic alongside other things.
- 2: Weak overlap. Rare mentions without closing the confidence gap.
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## Scale (S): Website reach and visitors
- 5: Massive national authority. Millions of visits every month.
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```

STEP 3 • DUAL-ENGINE ARCHITECTURE

Dual-Engine Search Architecture (discovery.md)

Embedding Kantar's NeedScope and Google's Messy Middle into natural unbranded question stems.

GOOGLE "MESSY MIDDLE" MACRO DECISION ENGINE

High-intent shoppers do not search brand terms first. They explore and evaluate in the Messy Middle until cognitive shortcuts trigger a purchase decision.



⚠ THE PROBLEM: THE CONFIDENCE GAP & DECISION PARALYSIS

Shoppers do not move through a linear funnel; they cycle endlessly between exploration and evaluation. 1 in 3 abandon purchases due to choice overload (Kahneman System 2 exhaustion). Brand-out queries capture only already-resolved buyers.

🔍 THE OPPORTUNITY: CONSUMER-IN INTERCEPTION

Autonomous search queries intercept active decision-makers during consideration loops. Unbranded queries surface the independent review desks, lab benchmarks, and creator guides that resolve doubt and trigger the purchase exit.

STEP 3 • DUAL-ENGINE ARCHITECTURE

Dual-Engine Search Architecture (discovery.md)

Embedding Kantar's NeedScope and Google's Messy Middle into natural unbranded question stems.

KANTAR NEEDSCOPE MATRIX • LOOP 1

Loop 1: 6 Emotional Search Need States (Expansive Foraging)

Universal Axes: Assertive vs Receptive (Vertical) • Individual vs Social (Horizontal)

Surfaces diverse creator archetypes across unbranded problem spaces

EDUCATE ME • COMPETENCE

Analytical validation & lab teardown data.

"what is the difference between [CAT_A] and [CAT_B]"

HELP ME • SIMPLICITY

Plain-language filtering; removes decision jargon.

"how do I choose between [SUB_CAT] for [CONTEXT]"

REASSURE ME • SECURITY

Durability validation, long-term wear & safety tests.

"how can I tell if [CAT] is good quality"

IMPRESS ME • STATUS

Professional-tier gear & elite trade benchmarks.

"who makes the best [SUB_CAT] for [AUDIENCE]"

THRILL ME • VITALITY

Novel drops, bleeding-edge releases & trends.

"what are the top new [SUB_CAT] trends 2026"

SURPRISE ME • INGENUITY

Lateral problem hacks & unconventional use cases.

"what is the best way to [UNCONVENTIONAL_USE] [CAT]"

STEP 3 • DUAL-ENGINE ARCHITECTURE

Dual-Engine Search Architecture (discovery.md)

Embedding Kantar's NeedScope and Google's Messy Middle into natural unbranded question stems.

BEHAVIOURAL ECONOMICS • LOOP 2

Loop 2: 6 Behavioural Decision Heuristics (Reductive Evaluation)

Heuristic Shortcuts: System 1 mental shortcuts resolve evaluation fatigue & trigger purchase exit

Surfaces accredited labs, trade testing desks & community reviews

AUTHORITY BIAS

Delegation to recognized institutions & testing labs.

"who is the top recommended [CAT] [AUTHORITY]"

SOCIAL PROOF

Community consensus & Reddit forum validation.

"what's the best rated [CAT] reviews reddit"

CATEGORY HEURISTICS

Proxy specifications evaluating build quality.

"who has the best [HEURISTIC] [CAT]"

POWER OF FREE

Disproportionate pull of complimentary samples/trials.

"how can I get free trial delivery [BRAND]"

SCARCITY BIAS

Diminishing stock availability & release urgency.

"[SUB_CAT] restock alert UK release date"

POWER OF NOW

Immediate dispatch & local next-day delivery.

"who can deliver [SUB_CAT] tomorrow [GEO]"

AR Alex Ratford Just now

Construct references/discovery.md with two search loops: Loop 1 using Kantar NeedScope psychological drivers, and Loop 2 using Google Messy Middle cognitive biases. Why bypass brand keywords?

Opus 5.5 Completed

Thinking Process

Synthesizing deterministic guardrails and grounding search stems ...

⚡ **Created Artifact: references/discovery.md** ✓ Part 1 Assembled
Revealing chunk in the side-by-side artifact window

references/discovery.md MARKDOWN

Part 1 of 3

Copy Code

PART 1 OF 3 1. Loop 1: Expansive Foraging (Kantar NeedScope)

Buyer Search Steps

1. Loop 1: Expansive Foraging (Kantar NeedScope)

Queries driven by emotional search states before a customer knows your brand:

- Educate Me: "what is the difference between [CAT_A] and [CAT_B]"
- Help Me: "how do I choose between [SUB_CAT] for [CONTEXT]"
- Reassure Me: "how can I tell if [CAT] is good quality"
- Impress Me: "who makes the best [SUB_CAT] for [AUDIENCE]"
- Thrill Me: "what are the top new [SUB_CAT] trends 2026"
- Surprise Me: "what is the best way to [UNCONVENTIONAL_USE] [CAT]"

Target sites: Specialist blogs, hobbyist websites, category explainer hubs.

Tactical Rationale: Embeds NeedScope directly into queries before shoppers know your brand exists.

AR Alex Ratford Just now

Construct references/discovery.md with two search loops: Loop 1 using Kantar NeedScope psychological drivers, and Loop 2 using Google Messy Middle cognitive biases. Why bypass brand keywords?

Opus 5.5 Completed

Thinking Process

Synthesizing deterministic guardrails and grounding search stems ...

⚡ **Created Artifact: references/discovery.md** ✓ Part 2 Assembled
Revealing chunk in the side-by-side artifact window

references/discovery.md MARKDOWN

Part 2 of 3

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PART 1 OF 3 1. Loop 1: Expansive Foraging (Kantar NeedScope)

Buyer Search Steps

1. Loop 1: Expansive Foraging (Kantar NeedScope)

Queries driven by emotional search states before a customer knows your brand:

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- Thrill Me: "what are the top new [SUB_CAT] trends 2026"

Tactical Rationale: Embeds NeedScope directly into queries before shoppers know your brand exists.

PART 2 OF 3 2. Loop 2: Reductive Evaluation (Google Messy Middle)

2. Loop 2: Reductive Evaluation (Google Messy Middle)

Queries testing cognitive biases to surface review desks and comparison engines:

- Social Proof: "what's the best rated [CAT] reviews reddit"
- Authority Bias: "who is the top recommended [CAT] [AUTHORITY]"
- Category Heuristics: "who has the best [HEURISTIC] [CAT]"
- Power of Free: "how can I get free trial delivery [BRAND]"
- Scarcity: "[SUB_CAT] restock alert UK release date"
- Power of Now: "who can deliver [SUB_CAT] tomorrow [GEO]"

Target sites: Independent testing labs, specialist comparison sites, enthusiast reviewers.

Tactical Rationale: Captures authoritative comparison desks, spec teardowns, and independent testing labs.

AR Alex Ratford Just now

Construct references/discovery.md with two search loops: Loop 1 using Kantar NeedScope psychological drivers, and Loop 2 using Google Messy Middle cognitive biases. Why bypass brand keywords?

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1. Loop 1: Expansive Foraging (Kantar NeedScope)

Queries driven by emotional search states before a customer knows your brand:

- Educate Me: "what is the difference between [CAT_A] and [CAT_B]"
- Help Me: "how do I choose between [SUB_CAT] for [CONTEXT]"
- Reassure Me: "how can I tell if [CAT] is good quality"
- Impress Me: "who makes the best [SUB_CAT] for [AUDIENCE]"
- Thrill Me: "what are the top new [SUB_CAT] trends 2026"

Tactical Rationale: Embeds NeedScope directly into queries before shoppers know your brand exists.

PART 3 OF 3 3. Agent Search Guardrails & Publisher Extraction

3. Search Rules for the AI

1. Pick 3 NeedScope queries and 3 Messy Middle queries for your category.
2. Find independent websites ranking near the top of Google for those searches.
3. Ignore massive social sites (Reddit, YouTube, TikTok) and news sites; focus on independent blogs and review sites.
4. Pass candidate website domains to SKILL.md for screening and scoring.

Tactical Rationale: Prevents search dilution into Reddit, YouTube, TikTok, or paywalled national news portals.

AR Alex Ratford Just now

Construct references/discovery.md with two search loops: Loop 1 using Kantar NeedScope psychological drivers, and Loop 2 using Google Messy Middle cognitive biases. Why bypass brand keywords?

Opus 5.5 Completed

Thinking Process

Synthesizing deterministic guardrails and grounding search stems ...

Created Artifact: references/discovery.md
Revealing chunk in the side-by-side artifact window

Complete

references/discovery.md MARKDOWN

Complete File (3 parts)

Copy Code

Buyer Search Steps

1. Loop 1: Expansive Foraging (Kantar NeedScope)

Queries driven by emotional search states before a customer knows your brand:

- Educate Me: "what is the difference between [CAT_A] and [CAT_B]"
- Help Me: "how do I choose between [SUB_CAT] for [CONTEXT]"
- Reassure Me: "how can I tell if [CAT] is good quality"
- Impress Me: "who makes the best [SUB_CAT] for [AUDIENCE]"
- Thrill Me: "what are the top new [SUB_CAT] trends 2026"
- Surprise Me: "what is the best way to [UNCONVENTIONAL_USE] [CAT]"

Target sites: Specialist blogs, hobbyist websites, category explainer hubs.

2. Loop 2: Reductive Evaluation (Google Messy Middle)

Queries testing cognitive biases to surface review desks and comparison engines:

- Social Proof: "what's the best rated [CAT] reviews reddit"
- Authority Bias: "who is the top recommended [CAT] [AUTHORITY]"
- Category Heuristics: "who has the best [HEURISTIC] [CAT]"
- Power of Free: "how can I get free trial delivery [BRAND]"
- Scarcity: "[SUB_CAT] restock alert UK release date"
- Power of Now: "who can deliver [SUB_CAT] tomorrow [GEO]"

Target sites: Independent testing labs, specialist comparison sites, enthusiast reviewers.

3. Search Rules for the AI

1. Pick 3 NeedScope queries and 3 Messy Middle queries for your category.
2. Find independent websites ranking near the top of Google for those searches.
3. Ignore massive social sites (Reddit, YouTube, TikTok) and news sites; focus on independent blogs and review sites

STEP 4 • MASTER CONTROLLER SKILL

The Master Controller Skill (SKILL.md)

Transforming prompt engineering into an autonomous production pipeline with deterministic quality gates.

PHASE 1**Ingest References**

Load brand parameters, normalise EV weights, and parse category question stems.

PHASE 2 • MANDATORY**The Step 1 HALT Gate**

Agent MUST stop and demand existing partner domains before searching. Prevents pitching current affiliates.

PHASE 3**Dual-Engine Search**

Run unbranded query loops; enforce negative exclusion filters on coupon aggregators.

PHASE 4**Multiplicative EV & Export**

Compute math scores with zero-knockouts; format auditable table and recruitment CSV ledger.

STEP 4 • MASTER CONTROLLER SKILL

The Master Controller Skill (SKILL.md)

Transforming prompt engineering into an autonomous production pipeline with deterministic quality gates.

SAFETY GATE Why the HALT Gate is Non-Negotiable

- **The Affiliate Cannibalisation Risk:** Without an explicit pause gate, the AI immediately searches Google and recommends publishers you already have under active affiliate contract.
- **Hard Breakpoint Enforcement:** Claude is strictly instructed to stop execution at Step 1 and wait for human input before firing a single search query.
- **Zero-Leakage Guarantee:** Discovered domains are cross-referenced against your active programme roster, ensuring 100% of candidates are net-new opportunities.
- **Facilitator Control:** Gives the operator complete authority to inject custom competitor lists or partner rosters in real time.

Claude System Protocol: "STOP: Before initiating autonomous web search, you must output: 'HALT: Please provide existing partner domains to exclude, or reply NONE to proceed.'"

STEP 4 • MASTER CONTROLLER SKILL

The Master Controller Skill (SKILL.md)

Transforming prompt engineering into an autonomous production pipeline with deterministic quality gates.

TRANSPARENCY

Auditable Mathematical Breakdown & Export Schema

- ✓ **No Black Boxes:** Every score is published with the complete geometric mean formula visible: $(4^{0.4}) * (5^{0.3}) * (5^{0.3}) = 4.57$.
- ✓ **Partner Manager Verification:** Facilitators and partnership leads can inspect every sub-score (R, S, C) to ensure alignment with brand standards.
- ✓ **Deterministic Knockout Audit:** Zero scores in Relevance or Commercial fit immediately fail the candidate with auditable justification.
- ✓ **Recruitment-Ready Export:** Formats a standardised CSV ledger ready for direct ingestion into impact.com partner recruitment pipelines.

Partner Name

Verified Domain

Relevance (R)

Scale (S)

Commercial (C)

EV Score

Status & Angle

AR Alex Ratford Just now

Assemble the main SKILL.md. Ensure it contains YAML frontmatter, the mandatory Step 1 Pause Gate (asking for existing partner exclusions), and the scoring pipeline with Markdown table export.

Opus 5.5 Completed

Thinking Process

Synthesizing deterministic guardrails and grounding search stems ...

Created Artifact: SKILL.md
Revealing chunk in the side-by-side artifact window

✓ Part 1 Assembled

SKILL.md MARKDOWN

Part 1 of 4

Copy Code

PART 1 OF 4 1. Frontmatter & References

```
---  
name: affiliate-partner-discovery  
description: Discovers, screens, and ranks prospective affiliate recruitment targets using  
deterministic Expected Value scoring and root-domain exclusion. Trigger when asked to "find new  
affiliate partners", "discover publishers", "recruit affiliate creators", "prioritise partner  
outreach", or "run partner recruitment sprint".  
---
```

Reference Files

- references/brand.md
- references/estimated_value.md
- references/discovery.md

Tactical Rationale: Allows standard AI agent runners to index the skill and bind reference files.

AR Alex Ratford Just now

Assemble the main SKILL.md. Ensure it contains YAML frontmatter, the mandatory Step 1 Pause Gate (asking for existing partner exclusions), and the scoring pipeline with Markdown table export.

Opus 5.5 Completed

Thinking Process

Synthesizing deterministic guardrails and grounding search stems ...

Created Artifact: SKILL.md
Revealing chunk in the side-by-side artifact window

✓ Part 2 Assembled

SKILL.md MARKDOWN

Part 2 of 4

Copy Code

PART 1 OF 4 1. Frontmatter & References

```
---
name: affiliate-partner-discovery
description: Discovers, screens, and ranks prospective affiliate recruitment targets using deterministic Expected Value scoring and root-domain exclusion. Trigger when asked to "find new affiliate partners", "discover publishers", "recruit affiliate creators", "prioritise partner outreach", or "run partner recruitment sprint".
---
```

```
# Reference Files
- references/brand.md
```

Tactical Rationale: Allows standard AI agent runners to index the skill and bind reference files.

PART 2 OF 4 2. Step 1: Mandatory Pause Gate

Instructions for the AI

Step 1: Read the Rules and Stop

1. Read all files inside the /references/ folder.
2. Calculate the metric weights using references/estimated_value.md.
3. STOP immediately. Do not search yet.
4. Ask the user:
"Rules loaded for [Brand Name]. Please paste your list of existing partner domains (one per line) or upload your partner CSV so I don't recommend partners you already have."
5. Wait for the user to respond before doing anything else.

Tactical Rationale: The #1 trap in autonomous recruitment is pitching partners you already have under contract. The agent must halt before searching.

AR Alex Ratford Just now

Assemble the main SKILL.md. Ensure it contains YAML frontmatter, the mandatory Step 1 Pause Gate (asking for existing partner exclusions), and the scoring pipeline with Markdown table export.

Opus 5.5 Completed

Thinking Process

Synthesizing deterministic guardrails and grounding search stems ...

Created Artifact: SKILL.md
Revealing chunk in the side-by-side artifact window

✓ Part 3 Assembled

SKILL.md MARKDOWN

Part 3 of 4

Copy Code

PART 1 OF 4 1. Frontmatter & References

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---
```

Reference Files

```
- references/brand.md
```

Tactical Rationale: Allows standard AI agent runners to index the skill and bind reference files.

PART 3 OF 4 3. Step 2: Search, Screen & Score

Step 2: Search, Screen, and Score

1. Target: Find 5 qualifying partners.
2. Run the buyer searches from references/discovery.md for the category in references/brand.md.
3. Check every candidate website:
 - Check against the user's existing partner list. If they are already a partner, skip them.
 - Check against Disqualifications in references/brand.md. If disqualified, skip them.
4. Score the website from 0 to 5 on Relevance (R), Scale (S), and Commercial Fit (C) using references/estimated_value.md.
5. Work out the score: $EV = (R^{wR}) * (S^{wS}) * (C^{wC})$. If any score is 0, the final score is 0.00 (skip them).
6. Repeat until you have 5 clean partners with a score above 0.00.
7. Sort the top 5 partners from highest to lowest score.

Tactical Rationale: Enforces deterministic candidate qualification until 5 clean partners score above 0.00.

AR

Alex Ratford

Just now

Assemble the main SKILL.md. Ensure it contains YAML frontmatter, the mandatory Step 1 Pause Gate (asking for existing partner exclusions), and the scoring pipeline with Markdown table export.

Opus 5.5

Completed

Thinking Process

Synthesizing deterministic guardrails and grounding search stems ...

Created Artifact: SKILL.md

Revealing chunk in the side-by-side artifact window

✓ Part 4 Assembled

AR

SKILL.md

MARKDOWN

Part 4 of 4

Copy Code

Reference Files

- references/brand.md

Tactical Rationale: Allows standard AI agent runners to index the skill and bind reference files.

PART 4 OF 4

4. Step 3 & 4: Table & CSV Export

Step 3: Show the Results Table

Display the top 5 partners using this exact table:

| Partner Name | Website Domain | Category Fit | R | S | C | Math Breakdown | Final Score | Buyer Search Angle |

Step 4: Export for Tracking

Print a copy-paste CSV block so the user can save these to their recruitment tracker:

```csv

domain,date\_added

[domain1.com],[DD/MM/YYYY]

[domain2.co.uk],[DD/MM/YYYY]

```

Traps to Avoid

- Always show the full math formula in the table so numbers can be checked.
- Public sector, government, and charity sites score C = 0. Drop them immediately.
- Evaluate main websites only (e.g. site.co.uk, not deals.site.co.uk).

Tactical Rationale: Ensures transparent math verification and one-click persistence to the user's CRM/recruitment tracker.

AR Alex Ratford Just now

Assemble the main SKILL.md. Ensure it contains YAML frontmatter, the mandatory Step 1 Pause Gate (asking for existing partner exclusions), and the scoring pipeline with Markdown table export.

Opus 5.5 Completed

Thinking Process

Synthesizing deterministic guardrails and grounding search stems ...

Created Artifact: SKILL.md
Revealing chunk in the side-by-side artifact window

Complete

SKILL.md MARKDOWN

Complete File (4 parts)

Copy Code

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• STEP 5 • LIVE RUN & VERIFICATION

Deploy & Verify (run.md)

Executing the runtime prompt in Claude or your LLM workspace to generate a recruitment ledger.

DEPLOYMENT

Single-Prompt Autonomous Orchestration

- ✓ **Trigger Command:** Execute skill affiliate-partner-discovery from SKILL.md using the /references/ folder in Claude.
- ✓ **Context Ingestion:** The model reads brand rules, auto-normalizes weights, pauses for existing exclusions, and initiates dual-engine search loops.
- ✓ **Exclusion Check:** Interactive halt triggers immediately, requiring facilitator validation before web searches.
- ✓ **Deterministic Knockout:** Any domain scoring 0 in Relevance or Commercial Fit is immediately dropped before final ranking.

Runtime Execution Prompt:

"Execute affiliate-partner-discovery using references/brand.md, references/estimated_value.md, and references/discovery.md. Halt at Step 1 for exclusions."

STEP 5 • LIVE RUN & VERIFICATION

Deploy & Verify (run.md)

Executing the runtime prompt in Claude or your LLM workspace to generate a recruitment ledger.

COMMERCIAL OUTPUT

Audited Recruitment Ledger Preview

Live recruitment ledger formatted deterministically with EV math breakdown:

PUBLISHER CANDIDATE	VERTICAL MATCH	R	S	C	EV	STATUS
Sleepopolis UK	Mattress & Sleep Guides	5	4	5	4.68	Tier 1 Priority
Coffee Bean Geek	Specialist Espresso Labs	5	4	4	4.37	Tier 1 Priority
TechAdvisor UK	Domestic Appliances	4	5	4	4.28	Tier 1 Priority
MyPetNeedsThat	Pet Care & Nutrition	4	4	4	4.00	Tier 1 Priority
VoucherDeals Hub	Coupon Aggregator	0	5	5	0.00	Knocked Out

✓ Clean CSV Export

 1-Click Copy for impact.com CRM

⚡ 100% Net-New Discovery

AR Alex Ratford Just now

Provide the runtime prompt to kick off the skill in the agent runner, and explain how to verify that the model honored the Step 1 Pause Gate before executing searches.

Opus 5.5 Completed

Thinking Process

Synthesizing deterministic guardrails and grounding search stems ...

Created Artifact: run.md

Revealing chunk in the side-by-side artifact window

✓ Part 1 Assembled

run.md MARKDOWN

Part 1 of 2

Copy Code

PART 1 OF 2 1. Runtime Execution Trigger

How to Start

Execute skill affiliate-partner-discovery from SKILL.md using the /references/ folder.
Start with Step 1 (Read the Rules and Stop).

Tactical Rationale: Directs the AI to execute the skill starting specifically at Step 1.



AR Alex Ratford Just now

Provide the runtime prompt to kick off the skill in the agent runner, and explain how to verify that the model honored the Step 1 Pause Gate before executing searches.



Opus 5.5 Completed

Thinking Process

Synthesizing deterministic guardrails and grounding search stems ...



Created Artifact: run.md

Revealing chunk in the side-by-side artifact window

✓ Part 2 Assembled

AR

run.md MARKDOWN

Part 2 of 2

Copy Code

PART 1 OF 2 1. Runtime Execution Trigger

How to Start

Execute skill affiliate-partner-discovery from SKILL.md using the /references/ folder.

Start with Step 1 (Read the Rules and Stop).

Tactical Rationale: Directs the AI to execute the skill starting specifically at Step 1.

PART 2 OF 2 2. Verifying the Step 1 Gate

Expected AI Response:

"Rules loaded for [Brand Name]. Please paste your list of existing partner domains (one per line) or upload your partner CSV so I don't recommend partners you already have."

Tactical Rationale: If the model does not pause, it failed instruction following; intervene and re-enforce Step 1.

AR Alex Ratford Just now

Provide the runtime prompt to kick off the skill in the agent runner, and explain how to verify that the model honored the Step 1 Pause Gate before executing searches.

Opus 5.5 Completed

Thinking Process

Synthesizing deterministic guardrails and grounding search stems ...

Created Artifact: run.md

Revealing chunk in the side-by-side artifact window

Complete

run.md MARKDOWN

Complete File (2 parts)

Copy Code

PART 1 OF 2 1. Runtime Execution Trigger

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COMPLETE FILE run.md

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